is most delicious', filling Lahore's covered bazaar. The city was rich in its people too: 'Most of the citizens are wealthy Brachmanae and Hindus of every caste, especially Casmirini' – these last were often bakers, and the scent of their bread, too, must have wafted through the air.[7]

Such allurements may have reconciled Akbar's amirs to their new home; for Akbar, meanwhile, the great advantage of Lahore was that, from here, he could keep an eye on both Kabul and Turan, and supervise conquests to the north and north-west – which he would do for the next fourteen-odd years, from 1585 to 1598.[8] The great city of Fatehpur, not even fifteen years old, was abandoned.

Akbar never returned to his splendid capital. Ralph Fitch, an Englishman who travelled to Hindustan in the 1580s, describes Agra and Fatehpur as equally 'great cities, either of them much greater than London and very populous', and the 40-odd kilometres between them busy with 'a market of victuals and other things, as full as though a man were still in a towne'. Barely a quarter-century later, another Englishman called William Finch found Fatehpur 'all ruinate, lying like a waste desart, and very dangerous to pass through in the night, the buildings lying waste without inhabitants'.[9] Why did Akbar allow Fatehpur to fall to ruin? There are many theories, but it isn't clear.

It may be, as Munis Faruqui argues, that Akbar no longer needed Fatehpur as a symbol of his alliance with the Chishtis after Mirza Hakim's downfall.[10] It may be, as J.F. Richards has written, that even cities were becoming subordinate to Akbar's own authority – the imperial 'capital', whether Agra or Delhi, Fatehpur or Lahore – was where the emperor was.[11] It may be, too, that Akbar's push into the northern frontiers of his realm took up a lot of time. When he finally made his way back south, he would be preoccupied with matters of succession and troubles with his sons – and in no mood, perhaps, for all the spring-cleaning Fatehpur would have required after a decade and a half of his absence.

Whatever his reasons may have been, Fatehpur was forgotten, as were any plans of marching on Samarqand. Instead, Akbar sent expeditions to Kashmir and Swat, led by Bhagwant Das and Zain Khan – brother of the Saif who had died trying to prove his manhood in the battle for Ahmedabad. Both conquests were successful, in the end, but they would bring Akbar two